

A pessary is a soft, removable device placed in the vagina to **support pelvic organ prolapse**. It eases the bulge and pressure without surgery. For many people a pessary is not just a short-term fix. It can be a comfortable choice for years.

How It Helps

The pessary sits in the vagina and **holds the dropped organs up**. This eases the feeling of a bulge, heaviness or pressure. It may also help you empty your bladder more easily. A different kind, the continence pessary, is made to help with **leaking** when you cough or exercise.

Getting Fitted

Pessaries come in many shapes and sizes. A **ring** is usually tried first. Other shapes, such as the Gellhorn, are used when a ring does not stay in. Your provider **fits** it in the office. It may take more than one visit, or more than one size, to find the right one. A good fit stays in place, lets you urinate, and does not hurt. You should not feel it.

If the vaginal tissue is thin or dry, your team may suggest **vaginal estrogen** cream. It may lower irritation and sores. Not everyone needs it.

Learn the Terms

Pessary

A removable device in the vagina that supports prolapse.

Prolapse

When pelvic organs drop and cause a bulge or pressure.

Ring pessary

The most common type. It is usually tried first.

Gellhorn

A pessary that fills more space. It is used when a ring falls out.

Fitting

Finding the size and shape that stays in and feels comfortable.

Erosion

A small sore on the vaginal wall from pressure. Regular care helps prevent it.

Vaginal estrogen

A low-dose hormone cream or tablet put in the vagina to help thin tissue.

Will I feel it, and can I be active? A pessary that fits well should not be felt. You can walk, work and exercise with it in. If it hurts, slips or falls out, the fit needs a change, so tell your team.

Caring for It

- 1 On your own:** many people learn to **take it out, wash it with soap and water, and put it back**. Your team will tell you how often.
- 2 With your team:** if you cannot remove it yourself, you will have **office visits** to clean it and check the tissue. These are often every few months, and at least every 6 months.
- 3** Either way, the pessary should come out **at least every 6 months**. Keep all follow-up visits.

What to Expect

- More **discharge** is common (up to 4 in 10 users). It can usually be managed.
- A small sore can form in 2–9 in 100 users. It often heals after the pessary is left out for a few weeks.
- Some people notice new leaking of urine once the prolapse is held up. Tell your team.
- Some types can stay in during sex. Others are taken out first. Ask your team.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- Pelvic **pain**, new bleeding, or discharge that smells bad
- A pessary that **falls out** or that you **cannot remove**
- Trouble urinating or having a bowel movement

Go to an emergency department if:

- You **cannot urinate** for several hours and your bladder feels full or painful
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

- 1.** A pessary is a safe way to treat prolapse without surgery, and it can work for years.
- 2.** A good fit stays in and is not felt. It may take a few tries.
- 3.** A forgotten pessary can cause serious sores. If family members help with your care, make sure they know it is there.